

Their married life did not run entirely smoothly—Claire suffered a number of miscarriages, before finally giving birth to a son, Pascal, in 1937.

In the same year, Messiaen won a prestigious commission to provide music for the Fêtes des belles eaux (a combination of fireworks, light, and water effects) at the World Fair in Paris. For this, he opted to create a futuristic sound by employing a sextet of ondes Martenot. Messiaen was certainly not the first composer to make use of this unusual electronic instrument, but it was to become one of his trademarks (see box).

Messiaen doubtless hoped for further commissions, but the outbreak of World War II put a brake on his career. Conscripted, he was sent to the front and was captured by the Germans at Verdun. Like thousands of his fellow prisoners, he was forced into a cattle-truck and endured a hellish four-day journey to the east with no food, water, or sanitation.

While imprisoned at Stalag VIIIA in Silesia (see box), Messiaen composed and performed one of the major musical landmarks of the 20th century. Played on ramshackle instruments, his Quartet for the End of Time was a startling chamber piece for violin, piano, cello, and clarinet—the only options that were available to him. Fittingly, given its wartime context, the theme was drawn from the Apocalypse, as described in the Book of Revelation.